

How much water does ai use actually?

Posted by u/Flamedghost7 • 0 points • 6 comments

I keep hearing large figures being thrown around and people saying that every query is eating up x amount of water. What are the most accurate estimates?

Comments

u/Conscious_Cut_6144 • 1 points • 2026-01-06 05:28 UTC

Significantly less water than we use watering our lawns.

u/Hello_Hangnail • 0 points • 2026-01-05 03:42 UTC

Look at a picture of Lake Mead circa 1980 and compare it to 2025

u/DiogenesKuon • 1 points • 2026-01-04 19:40 UTC

High end estimates are that all data centers combined may use as much as 68 billion gallons of water per year by 2028. Which sounds like a lot, but the US uses 322 gallons of water A DAY already. So it's a minuscule amount of water.

u/Shirking_Not_Working • 2 points • 2026-01-04 17:27 UTC

It's actually a pretty complicated question and depends on what all you're accounting for. Hank Green recently posted a [video that goes into this topic](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H_c6MWk7PQc)and IMO remains entertaining and informational enough to sit through.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-01-04 17:19 UTC

[removed]

u/calciplus • 1 points • 2026-01-04 17:18 UTC

One thing absent from most of these discussions is that water used to cool data centers isn't destroyed or contaminated, it's just warmer. So yes the heat is a factor but it's not like the water is gone.

u/xervir-445 • 0 points • 2026-01-04 17:15 UTC

Its hard to estimate since different models are more power (and therefor heat and water) efficient than others, and different companies serve different numbers of customers with varying water usage among them. GPT 3 apparently uses about half a liter per conversation, so with that number you can expect other models and companies to have similar numbers, likely with the more powerful models using more water than the less powerful ones.

u/consulent-finanziar • 0 points • 2026-01-04 17:13 UTC

